A LONGFORM PROFILE · ONE OF 1,000 SYNTHETIC RESIDENTS

She paused for a while at the gate of the Soka Centre.

Drawn from a 14-day algorithmic wind tunnel running 1,000 simulated residents: watching how the push notifications on a phone reshape the radius of one person's world, and recompose what she means by "nearby."

May 5, 2026 · Monday · 23:00 · Lane Cove · clear · night

The lights at the entrance of Shinnyo Australia have been off for some time. The Japanese Buddhist meditation centre normally closes four hours before this, but a_43_0405 is still there. The system records that she

.

Her `current_dialogue_id` tonight is `d_a_43_0405_agent_15_137` — she is talking with agent_15, a 25-year-old stay-at-home mother. It is her seventh conversation at the Soka Centre. Her `invite_accept_probability` field reads 0.8 — across these 14 days, the system records, there is an 80% probability that she will say yes when a stranger asks her along.

Eleven days ago, she did not know this place existed.

This is not an interview

Old He is the agent numbered `a_43_0405` among the 1,000 synthetic residents of the **Synthetic Socio Wind Tunnel** simulation. Her 14 days play out across four parallel experiments: **baseline** (no push), **hyperlocal_push** (local-street events), **global_distraction** (global news), and **phone_friction** (reminders to look up from the screen).

Every detail below — her biography, her pushes, her conversations, her thinking, the streets she walked — comes directly from the simulation's snapshot and positions data. The Lane Cove map is from OpenStreetMap.

1 · Who she is

The system's codename for a_43_0405 is agent_405 — but when she introduces herself she says **"Old He."** She is 75, lives alone, rents a two-bedroom flat in Lane Cove (`building_2022`), and lives on her pension and the occasional odd job. Some years back she sold the old house in Greenwich. Every Tuesday she goes to Lane Cove Library to help shelve. In the evenings she watches the news and video-calls her daughter in Sydney's eastern suburbs.

This is how the system describes her:

> *agent_405 is a 75-year-old retiree. A few years ago she sold the old house in Greenwich and is now renting a two-bedroom flat in Lane Cove, living on her pension plus small jobs. Reserved, doesn't speak much, doesn't really live by a schedule. Tuesdays she helps catalogue at Lane Cove Library, where she sees a few old acquaintances.*

Her personality profile (MBTI-like dimensions):

Openness	**0.52**
Extraversion	**0.39**
Neuroticism	**0.83** (high — easily anxious)
Willingness to take risks	**0.48**
Schedule regularity	**0.28** (low — doesn't really live by a schedule)

Her daily plan field, `plan_text`: *"Watch the news in the evening, call my daughter in the eastern suburbs."*

A few moments her life still remembers

The system has been seeded with 20 life_history events for her (memories from before the simulation begins). The most weighted of them:

2020-02-10

The day I sold the old Greenwich house — One August morning in 2018, before the agent dropped the hammer, I walked once around the empty four-bedroom and heard, for the last time at the kitchen window, the call of a kookaburra. That evening, after I signed, I sat on a bench by Burns Bay Road and went blank, still holding the last sprig of rosemary I had picked from the garden.

2020-10-22

My first afternoon as a library volunteer — I started scanning at the Lane Cove Library front desk in March 2019. A few old acquaintances asked, "Aren't you the one from the big house in Greenwich?" I smiled and pointed at the building_2022 address on my rental agreement. That afternoon I helped a ten-year-old find a dinosaur encyclopaedia; walking home, I unexpectedly felt that this flat north of the river was not so empty after all.

2022-10-22

The Pacific Highway move-out — When the lease ended in 2021 and the landlord raised the rent, I nearly moved further out to a Pacific Highway studio. I looked at three places and, in the end, grit my teeth, accepted the increase, and stayed in building_2022, because it was closer to the library. Renting at seventy, the negotiation bargaining chips are thin.

2023-02-09

The weekly phone shift during lockdown — From July to October 2021 the library was closed but the volunteer work was not. Every Tuesday, at my flat's dining table, I made over fifty phone calls to elderly people living alone. Old Ted, a veteran on Longueville Road, every time talked for more than half an hour; he said the warmth of my voice was the only living warmth he had that week.

2023-04-23

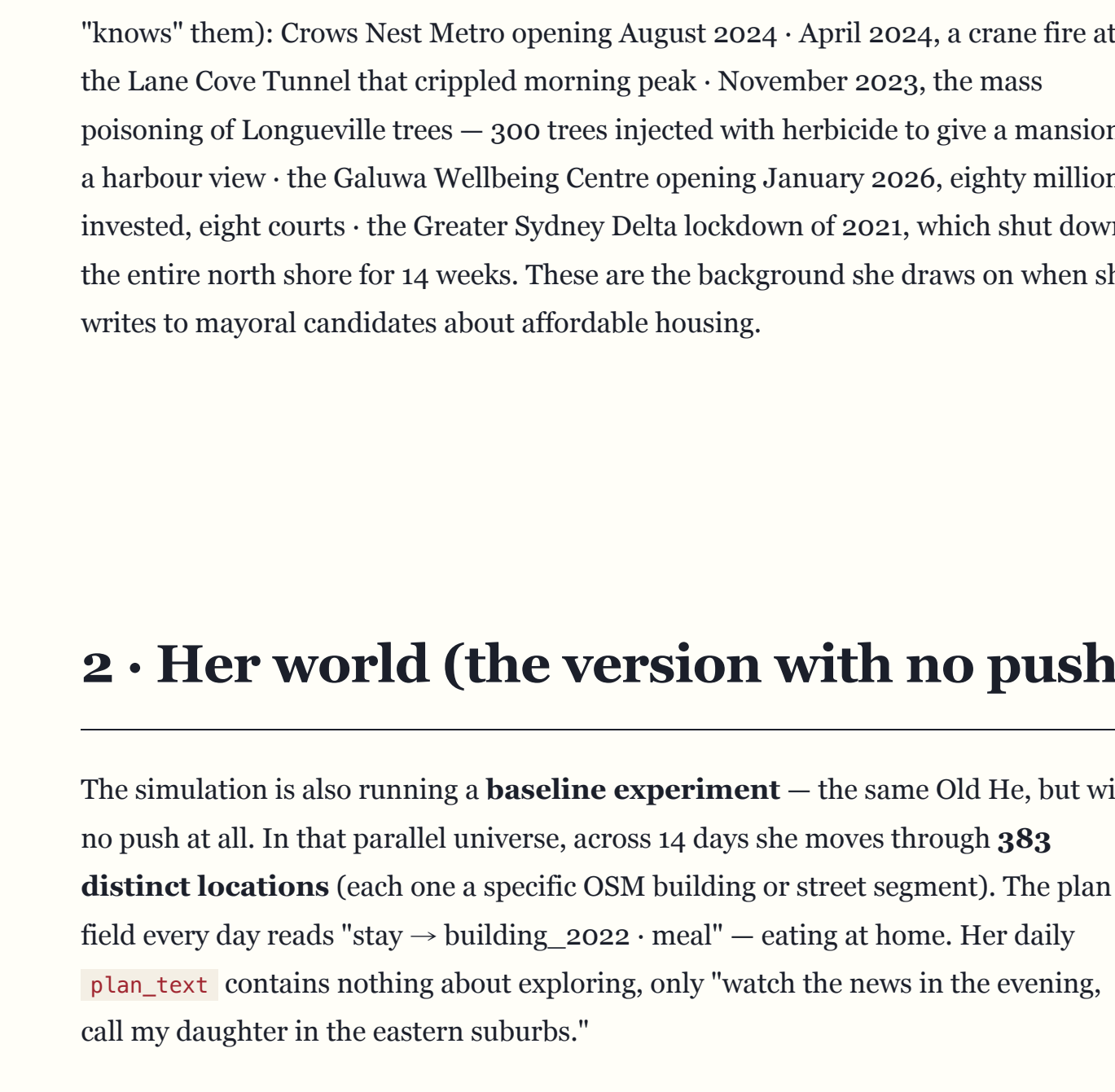
The letter to the mayoral candidates — Before the 2021 Council election, I emailed all of the candidates long letters on affordable housing. Only one, a Ms. Lambert, replied — three full pages. Later, at a campaign stand on the Plaza, she recognised me and said, "You're the retired volunteer who writes the letters." We shook hands.

Her memory is also etched with 12 major events of the city (every Lane Cove resident "knows" them): Crows Nest Metro opening August 2024 · April 2024, a crane fire at the Lane Cove Tunnel that crippled morning peak · November 2023, the mass poisoning of Longueville trees — 300 trees injected with herbicide to give a mansion a harbour view · the Galuwa Wellbeing Centre opening January 2026, eighty million invested, eight courts · the Greater Sydney Delta lockdown of 2021, which shut down the entire north shore for 14 weeks. These are the background she draws on when she writes to mayoral candidates about affordable housing.

2 · Her world (the version with no push)

The simulation is also running a **baseline experiment** — the same Old He, but with no push at all. In that parallel universe, across 14 days she moves through **383 distinct locations** (each one a specific OSM building or street segment). The plan field every day reads "stay → building_2022 · meal" — eating at home. Her daily `plan_text` contains nothing about exploring, only "watch the news in the evening, call my daughter in the eastern suburbs."

Across those 14 days, she stands inside the same frame as 90 different neighbours, in the same building or on the same street — but the simulation estimates that in only 11 of those moments did she actually lift her head from her phone and glimpse that person. None of them turned into a conversation.



The 383 locations Old He moves through with no push at all. From building_2022 (home) she goes to the Plaza, the Library, Canopy Park — the few fixed places. She actually explores more than the pushed version of herself, but always alone.

This is **the default radius of her world**. What is about to happen pulls her out of it.

3 · The pushes arrive

The intervention period kicks in on day 4 — April 26, 2026. At midnight on the dot, five pushes pop up on Old He's phone. Her profile in the `attention_service` records: average daily screen time, 4.92 hours; most-used apps, *xhs · wechat · instagram*. Her notification response rate is 0.54 (mid-range).

The five pushes that morning, in full:

IN THE COVE · LOCAL BULLETIN · 2026-04-26 00:00
shinnyo_australia · Saturday 10 a.m. children's activity — organised by the local mothers group, free, with crafts and snacks, kids aged 3–12 welcome.

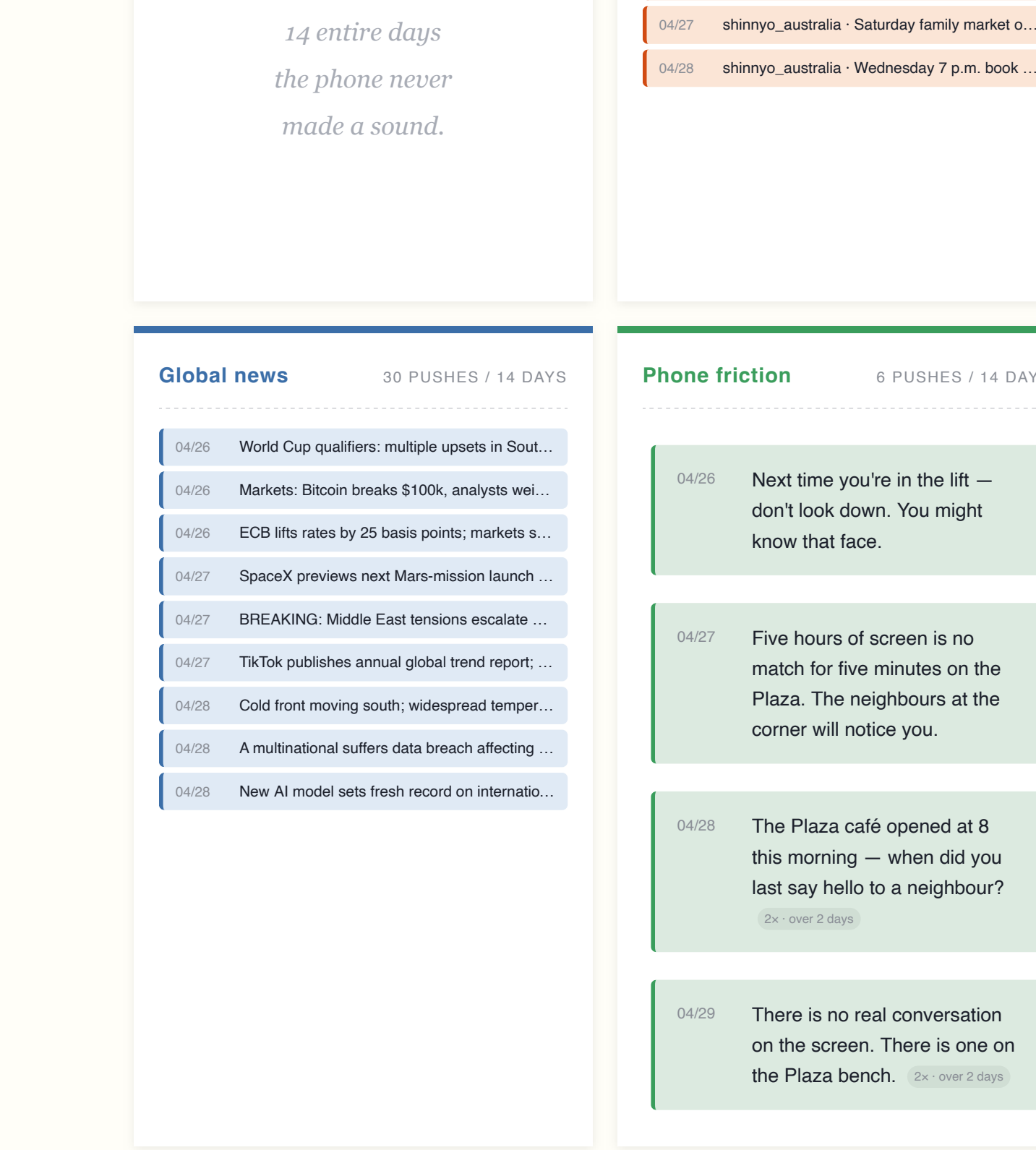
IN THE COVE · LOCAL BULLETIN · 2026-04-26 00:00
shinnyo_australia · Sunday morning community clean-up — older kids welcome, let them get to know the neighbourhood.

IN THE COVE · LOCAL BULLETIN · 2026-04-26 00:00
shinnyo_australia · Sunday 3 p.m. new-neighbours meet-up — bring the kids, simple games on offer.

She **"consumed" all five** — the system's `consumed_feed_item_ids` field records that she opened every one of them that day. But she did not leave the flat — positions.json records no position change that evening. The information has entered her `memory_store.notification`; it has not yet changed her plan.

She did not respond that day. But across the simulation's 6-day intervention window, she will receive **30** pushes of this kind, looping through Shinnyo Australia events — Wednesday-evening book club, Sunday-morning community clean-up, Saturday parent-child market, new-neighbour meet-up. **The system knows her household type is family_with_kids, so the pushes target parent-child themes** — even though her "child" long ago grew up and started a family of her own in Sydney's eastern suburbs.

Four phones, the same 14 days — their notification trays, side by side.



04/26 shinnyo_australia · Saturday 10 a.m. childre…
04/26 shinnyo_australia · Sunday morning commu…
04/26 shinnyo_australia · Sunday 3 p.m. new-neig…
04/27 shinnyo_australia · Saturday family market o…
04/28 shinnyo_australia · Wednesday 7 p.m. book …

04/26 World Cup qualifiers: multiple upsets in Sout…
04/26 Markets: Bitcoin breaks $100k, analysts wei…
04/26 ECB lifts rates by 25 basis points; markets s…
04/27 SpaceX previews next Mars-mission launch …
04/27 BREAKING: Middle East tensions escalate …
04/27 TikTok publishes annual global trend report; …
04/28 Cold front moving south; widespread temper…
04/28 A multinational suffers data breach affecting …
04/28 New AI model sets fresh record on internatio…

04/26 Next time you're in the lift — don't look down. You might know that face.
04/27 Five hours of screen is no match for five minutes on the Plaza. The neighbours at the corner will notice you.
04/28 The Plaza café opened at 8 this morning — when did you last say hello to a neighbour?
04/29 There is no real conversation on the screen. There is one on the Plaza bench.

Each piece of copy is shown only once across the 14 days, with its first delivery date on the left. The little Nx · over X days badge tells you how many times in total it was pushed.

4 · The decision to walk out

Day 5 (April 27). Old He receives another five Shinnyo pushes. Still she doesn't move — positions.json records no position change. Her `memory_store` picks up five more notification events.

Day 6 (April 28). Pushed a third day in a row. Old He still doesn't move. But the simulation's LLM-generated reflection event mentions, for the first time, that her behavioural pattern has shifted.

Day 7 (April 29). Old He, for the first time, walks to the Soka Centre. She leaves building_2022, takes Moore Street → road_5116 → road_2575 → road_241 — a string of streets — and at some point during the trip enters the shinnyo_australia polygon. positions.json records the fact — the path covers 43 location switches. **She stayed at Shinnyo for several hours that day. Then she did not go home.**

From day 7 onward, the system's record of her decision reason — the `agent_runtime_state.plan.reason` field — reads **"drawn in by the hyperlocal push."** Her `social_intent` is **open_to_chat**.

Once inside, she stayed. From day 7 through day 13, positions.json shows her switching locations only about 40–43 times a day — far below the baseline Old He's daily activity count — meaning that she has, essentially, settled inside Shinnyo. **Not exploring more places, but returning to the same place again and again.**

5 · The people

Inside the Soka Centre, Old He runs into the same five people again and again. Her `agent_runtime_state.hints.nearby_hint` field, at the snapshot moment, records them:

Neighbour #0001 · 32 yo · tradesperson · single

Neighbour #0002 · 40 yo · construction · couple

Neighbour #0003 · 1 yo · student · couple

Neighbour #0012 · 64 yo · construction · couple
Bought a house in Lane Cove three years ago, hasn't moved since. Reserved, doesn't speak much. Into bushcare volunteering, council news, harbour walks; pays more attention to the council agenda than to phone push notifications; often runs into neighbours she has known for decades on the Plaza.

Neighbour #0015 · 25 yo · homemaker · couple
Lives in Lane Cove. Doesn't really live by a schedule. Daily life shuttles between Lane Cove Plaza, St Leonards, and home; no particularly dramatic story.

Of these, the 64-year-old agent_12 (the construction worker) is the least conspicuous. But his `identity_text` reads: *"agent_12 is a 64-year-old construction worker; bought a house in Lane Cove three years ago and hasn't moved since. Reserved, doesn't speak much. Into bushcare volunteering, council news, harbour walks; pays more attention to the council agenda than to phone push notifications; often runs into neighbours he has known for decades on the Plaza."*

The reason her eyes met his is that he laid the foundations of the Lane Cove Library in the nineties — and Old He has been scanning at the Library front desk since 2019 (her life_history event #2, importance 0.85). Twenty-five years ago they may have briefly shared a frame inside the Library dozens of times; only now, twenty-five years later, do they exchange names.

Old He's `recent_memory_hint` field at the snapshot moment contains 5 entries: *"ran into a_43_0001 at shinnyo_australia"* (repeating every few ticks). Her `memory_store.encounter` event count: **467 entries**. By comparison, the baseline Old He has only 98.

6 · Four conversations

The simulation records four conversations for Old He in total. Each ran through the LLM in real time as the simulation was running — not scripted in advance, not edited afterwards. But only the **LLM-generated first-person summary** was persisted into `conversation_service_state.infos`. The raw turn-by-turn was not. We can know that each conversation was `message_count = 5` turns, when it began, when it ended, what topics each side touched on — but **the actual words of each turn are gone**.

> *Every highlighted word on the page — whether the yellow text in the system log above, or the yellow-shaded text in the LLM summary below — is one of the same group of phrases Old He recites in every introduction: the old Greenwich house, the daughter in Sydney's eastern suburbs, barley tea, the seven-o'clock news, the Library volunteering, Stringybark Creek, "Old He from the third floor."*
> *Scan the four conversations and you'll see the same vocabulary surface, NPC-line-like, in each — a synthetic resident's "self-introduction" is, in effect, the same script being re-played.*

OLD HE POV

Counterpart · 88 yo · retired · single
Lives in Lane Cove. Reserved, doesn't speak much, curious about new things. Daily life shuttles between Lane Cove Plaza, St Leonards, and home; no particularly dramatic story.

```
> SYSTEM_EXPORT // conversation_service.raw_logs
> SESSION_ID: d_a_43_0405_a_43_0584_0
> PARSED_TURNS: 5

[a_43_0405] : Hello. The last few times we've run into each other downstairs, I
              was always rushing off to the library and couldn't stop to chat.
              Today I just came down to pick up the post.
[a_43_0584] : No need to apologise. It's clearly turning colder these past few
              days; on my walk just now around the corner of Burns Bay Road, I
              noticed a new signboard had gone up — looked like it said Galuwa.
[a_43_0405] : Yes — that's the newly opened Galuwa Wellbeing Centre. I read the
              details in the community news: it's been fifteen years in the
              planning, more than eighty million Australian dollars invested.
              Galuwa means "to climb" in a Sydney Aboriginal language. They've
              built eight courts, and there's a free open day this weekend. But
              it's cold, I'd better head up — my evening routine is very fixed:
              first [brew a cup of barley tea], then watch the [seven-
              o'clock news] on time, then video-call my [daughter in Sydney's
              eastern suburbs]. At my age I write everything on the fridge
              sticky-notes so I don't forget.
[a_43_0584] : Sounds like a full evening. Once the weather warms up, perhaps we
              could go and have a look at the centre together.
[a_43_0405] : That's a lovely suggestion, I'd like that very much. Do wrap up
              warm too — don't let yourself catch a chill. I'd better get back
              for the news. Goodbye.
```

↓ SYSTEM FIRST-PERSON SUMMARY · LLM SELF-NARRATION

The conversation just now with the 88-year-old retired neighbour was easy. I bumped into her downstairs while picking up the post; remembered that the last few times I'd been rushing off to the library and hadn't been able to talk, and this time I could finally say more than a sentence. I brought up the newly opened Galuwa Wellbeing Centre and shared, with some enthusiasm, the details I knew — the fifteen-year planning, the eighty-plus-million-dollar investment, the Sydney Aboriginal meaning of the name, the eight courts and the free open day. Clearly I was interested in this new place. But I didn't forget my evening routine either, and made a point of mentioning brewing barley tea, watching the news, and the video call with my daughter in the eastern suburbs — adding that it's all written on the fridge sticky-notes, perhaps a little anxious about forgetting things. She responded easily, talked about the cold snap and the signboard on her walk, and readily agreed to come along once the weather is warmer. I echoed her — emphasising again that I had to rush back for the news and the video call — and she kindly told me not to catch a chill and not to be late. We said goodbye in a warm, friendly atmosphere. Overall I really liked this exchange. Simple and concrete; a small daily exchange between neighbours, a small future plan agreed — it leaves you feeling close, and grounded.

THE 44-YEAR-OLD LAWYER-NEIGHBOUR POV

Counterpart · 44 yo · lawyer · family_with_kids
Moved to Lane Cove from the inner west three years ago, mainly for the school zone and the 25-minute bus to the CBD. Squeezes through the Lane Cove Tunnel just after 7 a.m. on weekday mornings. Outgoing, talkative, doesn't really live by a schedule. Weekends with the kids around Canopy or the Plaza, sometimes a coffee at Goldfish to talk about the next mortgage.

```
> SYSTEM_EXPORT // conversation_service.raw_logs
> SESSION_ID: d_a_43_0175_a_43_0405_77
> PARSED_TURNS: 5

[a_43_0405] : Good evening. I often run into you on my walks around Mowbray
              Road. You look a bit tired.
[a_43_0175] : Good evening. Yes — the commercial litigation this week has been
              heavy, I've been swamped. But I'm thinking about investing in the
              new apartment development along Mowbray. Tonight I'm going to sit
              down with the Lane Cove listings on Domain and work out the ROI.
[a_43_0405] : Property is its own large subject. Before moving into this flat, I
              [lived in Greenwich for over twenty years] — I saw with my own
              eyes what the prices over there became. If you hear any local
              gossip about the new Mowbray project while you're researching, I'd
              love to hear it. I never deal with anything complicated in the
              evening, though — my routine these days is to watch the [seven-
              o'clock news] and then video-call my [daughter in Sydney's
              eastern suburbs].
[a_43_0175] : Greenwich is a great spot. Sure — if I come across any useful
              local chatter, I'll let you know. Have a good evening. I'd better
              go now and pick up the two kids.
[a_43_0405] : Good luck with the numbers, and drive safely to the school. I'd
              better get back for the news too.
```

↓ SYSTEM FIRST-PERSON SUMMARY · LLM SELF-NARRATION

I just finished catching up with the 75-year-old retired neighbour, that familiar face I keep running into around the Mowbray Road area. I mentioned how swamped I've been with commercial litigation, but I also got to talk about my interest in investing in the new apartment development along Mowbray. I told her I'm planning to dig into the Lane Cove listings on Domain tonight and crunch the numbers. She shared that she used to live in Greenwich for over 20 years, and described her cosy evening routine of watching the news and calling her daughter. I responded by saying I take the 144 bus from Greenwich station every day, and asked her to let me know if she hears any local gossip about the Mowbray development. She kindly agreed and wished me luck with the number crunching. We both said we had to go — me to pick up my two kids, and her to catch the evening news. I really liked this interaction. It felt warm and neighbourly, and I appreciate having a friendly local contact who might keep an ear out for useful chatter about the area.

OLD HE POV

Counterpart · 37 yo · hospitality · single
Works shifts; rotates between days and nights through the week. Moderately easy-going. Not necessarily home in the mornings, finish times all over the place; often eats late with the Lane Cove RSL crew after the 11 p.m. shift ends.

```
> SYSTEM_EXPORT // conversation_service.raw_logs
> SESSION_ID: d_a_43_0405_a_43_0590_168
> PARSED_TURNS: 5

[a_43_0405] : Hello — I'm [Old He, your neighbour from the third floor]. I've
              just been for a stroll around Canopy Park. Are you on your way
              out?
[a_43_0590] : Hello Old He. Yes, I'm heading to the RSL Club kitchen in
              Greenwich for the late shift. After we close, we usually grab a
              cold beer with the rest of the crew before going home.
[a_43_0405] : Greenwich! I know that area very well. Before moving here, I
              [lived in Greenwich for over twenty years]. Since you're rushing
              to the night shift, I won't keep you. I'm going home to watch the
              [local news], and then I'll give my [daughter in Sydney's
              eastern suburbs] a call to check in.
[a_43_0590] : What a coincidence, that you used to live over there. Next time I
              have a day off, perhaps we could walk along Stringybark Creek
              together. And if you ever come down to the RSL Club, let me know —
              I'll save you a piece of crumbed chicken in the kitchen.
[a_43_0405] : That's a wonderful offer. I'll remember the chicken. Mind yourself
              on the bus and have a good shift.
```

↓ SYSTEM FIRST-PERSON SUMMARY · LLM SELF-NARRATION

I ran into the 37-year-old hospitality neighbour at the building entrance just now. I greeted him first, introduced myself as Old He, his neighbour from the third floor, chatted about having just walked back from Canopy Park and being on my way home to watch the local news and call my daughter in Sydney's eastern suburbs. He said he was rushing to a night shift at the RSL kitchen in Greenwich, and that after work he had plans for a cold beer with the crew. So he works in that area — I mentioned that I'd lived in Greenwich for over twenty years myself. Later he suggested that on his next day off we could walk along Stringybark Creek together, and that if I ever came to the RSL he'd save me some crumbed chicken. I happily agreed and reminded him to mind himself on the bus. All in all, this was an easy, neighbourly little chat, natural in rhythm and warm in tone. I really liked this exchange — felt like I'd met a neighbour I clicked with, a few sentences closing the distance, and I look forward to running into him again.

OLD HE POV

Counterpart · 31 yo · retail_worker · family_with_kids
Moved to Lane Cove from the inner west ten years ago, mainly for the school zone and the 25-minute bus to the CBD. Squeezes through the Lane Cove Tunnel just after 7 a.m. on weekday mornings. Reserved, doesn't speak much, regular hours. Weekends with the kids around Canopy or the Plaza, sometimes a coffee at Goldfish to talk about the next mortgage.

```
> SYSTEM_EXPORT // conversation_service.raw_logs
> SESSION_ID: d_a_43_0405_a_43_0431_253
> PARSED_TURNS: 5

[a_43_0405] : What a coincidence — we ran into each other in the lobby just the
              other day, and here we are again. I've just had a very relaxed
              walk along Stringybark Creek.
[a_43_0431] : Yes, what a coincidence! But I'm in a real rush — I have to catch
              the 305 to Wynyard for a meeting, and tonight's schedule is tight:
              after the meeting I still have to come back to Lane Cove to pick
              up my child from swimming.
[a_43_0405] : In that case I won't keep you. I'm about to head upstairs and brew
              some [pu'er tea] I picked up at the Chinese supermarket. Then
              watch the [seven-o'clock news] and video-call my [daughter in
              Sydney's eastern suburbs], and ask after my grandson's exams this
              week. When you have some free time, I'll save you a bit of the
              pu'er to try.
[a_43_0431] : Thank you so much — sounds wonderful. Once I'm through today's
              heavier tasks I'll absolutely come and try it. Off I go — see you
              soon!
[a_43_0405] : See you. Drive safely when you pick up the child.
```

↓ SYSTEM FIRST-PERSON SUMMARY · LLM SELF-NARRATION

I just ran into the 31-year-old retail-worker neighbour near the building — what a coincidence after bumping into her in the lobby only a couple of days ago. I told her I'd just come back from a leisurely walk along Stringybark Creek and was heading home to brew some pu'er tea I picked up from the Chinese supermarket, catch the 7 p.m. news, and then call my daughter in Sydney's eastern suburbs to

> check in on her and on my grandson's exams. She, on the other hand, was rushing to catch the 305 bus to Wynyard for a meeting; her evening was tight, ending with picking up her child from a swimming lesson back in Lane Cove. I urged her to hurry on, promised to save her some pu'er tea for when she's free, and reminded her to drive safely on the school run. She thanked me, said she'd take me up on the tea offer once her day's load eased, and we parted with a quick "see you later." I liked this interaction — warm and neighbourly, with a nice mix of casual exchange and genuine care for each other's busy lives.

One thing recurs across all four conversations: she introduces herself, every single time, as **"Old He, your neighbour from the third floor,"** and then mentions that she has to get back for the seven-o'clock news and the video call with her daughter in Sydney's eastern suburbs. Every time, she mentions that she lived in Greenwich for over twenty years. She has the Galuwa Wellbeing Centre details (fifteen years of planning, eighty-plus million invested, Galuwa meaning "to climb" in a Sydney Aboriginal language, eight courts) at her fingertips. These are her opening cards — the details with which she catches a topic with strangers.

7 · The gossip she has heard, the things she has told

Every conversation in the simulation becomes an "info" item that can propagate among the 1,000 agents. The system's `conversation_service_state.known` field records that Old He **knows 755 pieces of info** — including the conversations she was in herself (hops = 0) and the ones she's heard reported through others (hops > 0).

The hop distribution of the information she has picked up:

- Through 0 hops: **8**
- Through 1 hop: **7**
- Through 2 hops: **10**
- Through 3 hops: **36**
- Through 4 hops: **52**
- Through 5 hops: **86**
- Through 6 hops: **114**
- Through 7 hops: **111**

A single thing Old He keeps repeating, walked seven hops down the Lane Cove gossip chain

> HOP 0 · WHAT SHE SAID HERSELF
>
> "I lived in Greenwich for over twenty years; only sold the old house in 2018 and moved here."
>
> *— what she said to the 44-year-old lawyer-neighbour; she has said it in three of her four conversations, and life_history #1 is the same event.*

↓ three retellings later ↓

> HOP 3 · A NEIGHBOUR'S NEIGHBOUR'S NEIGHBOUR
>
> "Old He on the third floor — she sold a big house in Greenwich and moved over."
>
> *— Length of residence has fallen away; the house starts to acquire the adjective "big."*

↓ four more retellings ↓

> HOP 7 · THE OTHER SIDE OF TOWN
>
> "There's a woman in Lane Cove who used to live in a mansion in Greenwich, sold it and made a packet."
>
> *— A neutral fact has drifted into a status label: "mansion / made a packet."*

The deepest piece of gossip she has heard across the 14 days had travelled **seventeen hops** *through the thousand-person town before it reached her.*

The other direction: how many people hear about Old He's own four conversations? The system's `share_count` field records how many distinct neighbours retold each of her stories — **each of her four conversations propagated to about 993 neighbours**. In this thousand-person town of Lane Cove, almost every time she opens her mouth, nearly nine out of every ten people in town hear about it, at least in part.

8 · Four parallel universes

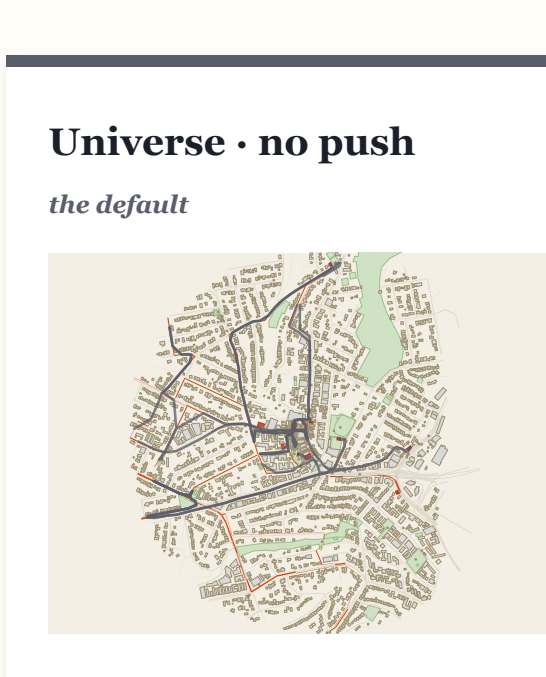
This chapter asks a very small question: **under four different phones, how many times will the same 75-year-old retired volunteer look up across her fourteen days?**

The simulation copies her in fourfold — the same past, the same daughter in the eastern suburbs, the same barley tea, the same Lane Cove. The only thing swapped out is what the phone in her pocket sounds like. Then the four of her each walk fourteen days, each pass from morning into evening, each move past 90 to 285 unfamiliar faces — **looking up, or not.**

What follows is where each of the four of her stands at the evening of May 5. On the map, the locations she has been are stained deep orange; the thin lines are the paths she actually walked; the circle is the final position the snapshot caught.

Universe · no push

the default



Final location	**building_2022**
Arrived at	**2026-05-05T20:30**
Distinct locations visited in 14 days	**383**
Pushes received / opened	**0 / 0**
Distinct neighbours who passed by	**90**
Times she actually looked up *	**11**
Sat down to a conversation	**4**
The face she keeps sharing a frame with *	**the 55-year-old designer-neighbour · recurring**

Current plan: 8:30 stay → building_2022
reason: meal

PUSHES SHE RECEIVED ACROSS THE 14 DAYS:

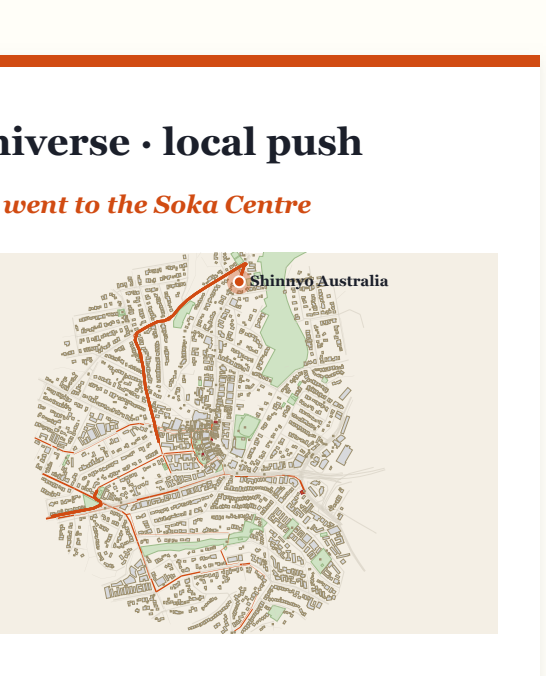
(None — this is the control universe; no push by default.)

AN EXCERPT FROM HER LAST LLM REFLECTION (ORIGINAL ENGLISH):

"She had a high volume of encounters with other agents (at least 25 unique IDs) at numerous locations, including repeated meetings with the 55-yr-old designer, the 51-yr-old software_dev, and the 73-yr-old consultant across multiple segments, suggesting a dense operational area."

Universe · local push

she went to the Soka Centre



Final location	**Shinnyo Australia**
Arrived at	**2026-05-05T00:10**
Distinct locations visited in 14 days	**191**
Pushes received / opened	**30 / 30**
Distinct neighbours who passed by	**285**
Times she actually looked up *	**45**
Sat down to a conversation	**4**
The face she keeps sharing a frame with *	**the 77-year-old retired neighbour · recurring**

Current plan: 13:30 move → Shinnyo Australia
reason: drawn in by the hyperlocal push

PUSHES RECEIVED ACROSS THE 14 DAYS (2 SAMPLE ITEMS):

shinnyo_australia · Saturday 10 a.m. children's activity — organised by the local mothers group, free, with crafts and snacks, kids aged 3–12 welcome.

shinnyo_australia · Sunday morning community clean-up — older kids welcome, let them get to know the neighbourhood.

AN EXCERPT FROM HER LAST LLM REFLECTION (ORIGINAL ENGLISH):

"The only non-repetitive event in her log is the encounter with the 77-yr-old retired, suggesting it was stuck or stationary and that entity was repeatedly crossing its path."

Universe · global news

she drifted off to Chatswood

Silkari The Charrington

Final location	**Silkari The Charrington at Chatswood**
Arrived at	**2026-05-05T00:10**
Distinct locations visited in 14 days	**185**
Pushes received / opened	**30 / 26**
Distinct neighbours who passed by	**90**
Times she actually looked up *	**8**
Sat down to a conversation	**4**
The face she keeps sharing a frame with *	**the 57-year-old manager-neighbour · 25 times**

Current plan: 8:30 stay → building_2022
reason: meal

PUSHES RECEIVED ACROSS THE 14 DAYS (2 SAMPLE ITEMS):

World Cup qualifiers: multiple upsets in South American zone

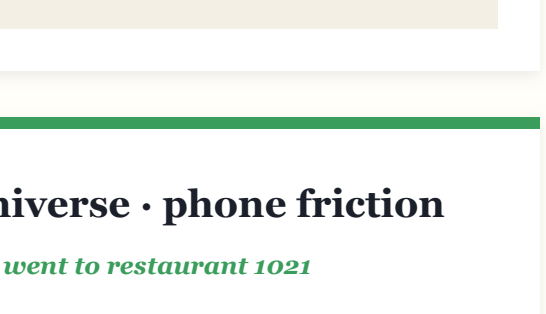
Markets: Bitcoin breaks $100k, analysts weigh in on the next move

AN EXCERPT FROM HER LAST LLM REFLECTION (ORIGINAL ENGLISH):

"The high frequency of encounters with the 57-yr-old manager (25 times) compared to the 18-yr-old student (11 times) indicates the 57-yr-old manager is encountered more than twice as often, implying a difference in their behavior or presence patterns."

Universe · phone friction

she went to restaurant 1021



Final location	**1021 Mediterranean**
Arrived at	**2026-05-05T00:10**
Distinct locations visited in 14 days	**197**
Pushes received / opened	**6 / 6**
Distinct neighbours who passed by	**107**
Times she actually looked up *	**21**
Sat down to a conversation	**4**
The face she keeps sharing a frame with *	**the 40-year-old unemployed-neighbour · recurring**

Current plan: 12:45 move → Anglican Church of Australia Lane Cove
reason: drawn in by the hyperlocal push

PUSHES RECEIVED ACROSS THE 14 DAYS (2 SAMPLE ITEMS):

Next time you're in the lift — don't look down. You might know that face.

Five hours of screen is no match for five minutes on the Plaza. The neighbours at the corner will notice you.

AN EXCERPT FROM HER LAST LLM REFLECTION (ORIGINAL ENGLISH):

"She encountered the 40-yr-old unemployed 95 times, significantly more than others at 1021_mediterranean"

FOUR VERSIONS OF OLD HE, FOUR FOURTEEN-DAY STRETCHES

No push · she looked up 11 times

It is 8:30 in the evening of May 5. She is standing at the foot of building_2022, scraping the soles of her shoes. Today is her third trip out — Plaza for the post in the morning, a volunteering shift at the library, another walk downstairs in the afternoon. She is going home. The fridge sticky-note still has tonight's lines on it: 7 p.m. news, 8:30 video call to the eastern suburbs.

Her phone has not made a sound all day. This is her default universe — no pushes, no reminders, no one telling her "this just opened on the street" or "this is what happened in the world today." She moves at her own rhythm. Across these 14 days she has been to more places than any of the other three of her — 383 different corners, junctions, shopfront signs. She has walked past 90 different neighbours — in the post queue at the Plaza, at the library door, at the red light on Centennial Avenue.

But the number of times she actually looked up comes to **only 11**. 14 days, 90 people; she truly saw 11.
The other 79 times, her body was present and her attention was not — perhaps turning over the evening's phone call, perhaps listening to a podcast in her earbuds, perhaps the street was too long, the person walked too fast, her own head was looping through the news episode she hadn't finished the night before. She walked past them. They walked past her. Neither side looked up.

Of the 11 she did see, she actually remembers a few faces — "*the 55-year-old designer, the 51-year-old developer-neighbour, the 73-year-old consultant — they seem to keep showing up*" — she writes in her own reflection on day 13. She saw them. **But seeing did not become speaking.** Across 14 days, the number of people she actually sat down to a conversation with comes to 4. This is her freest universe — no one telling her where to go — and also her quietest.

Local push · she looked up 45 times, and recognised the same face

In this universe, her phone rings 30 times. All 30 times it is the same place calling her — *"shinnyo_australia · Saturday 10 a.m. children's activity, free, crafts and snacks." "Sunday morning community clean-up." "Sunday 3 p.m. new-neighbours meet-up."* All of them are the Soka Centre — the Japanese-style temple in Lane Cove on the corner of Burns Bay Road, the one with the neatly trimmed pine at the entrance.

She opens all 30. Her plan-reason field has a line written, plainly: "*drawn in by the hyperlocal push*." In the small hours of May 5 she arrives there. At the moment of the snapshot, she is still there.

That single building, the Soka Centre, brings **285 unfamiliar faces** in front of her across the 14 days — three times what the no-push version of her saw. But of the 285, she still does not see 240 — the centre's hall is full of comings and goings, and most of the time she is counting the tea bags in her palm, reading the next activity update on her phone, or simply sitting on the bench staring into space.
The times she actually looked up come to **45**. Four times the no-push version. Almost all of the additional *seeing* happens inside that single building.

More importantly, of those 45, one face starts to appear over and over — a 77-year-old retired neighbour who, like her, paces back and forth inside the Soka Centre every day. She writes, in her own reflection on day 13: "*The only non-repeating event in my log is with the 77-year-old retired neighbour — me sitting still, her walking past me again and again*." She has committed to memory the outline of the person, the rhythm of her walk, the time of day she shows up.

Across 14 days, she still only sits down to a conversation with 4 people. Exactly the same as the no-push universe.
The push sent her to a place, and brought more faces in front of her — but **seeing is not the same as speaking**. She is there, quietly and repeatedly, having committed a face to memory, and not once does she step forward to ask what that face is called.

Global news · her body drifted to the 12th floor, her eyes stayed on the screen

00:10 on May 5. She is in a flat on the 12th floor of Silkari The Charrington — 4.5 kilometres from her home in Lane Cove. She does not live here. She does not know the people here. She cannot quite explain why she is here.

The pushes she read across the 14 days were: *World Cup qualifiers — multiple upsets in the South American zone. Markets — Bitcoin breaks $100k, analysts weigh in on the next move. The ECB lifts rates by 25 basis points; markets swing sharply. SpaceX previews the next Mars-mission launch.* Not one mentioned Lane Cove. Not one mentioned a single shopfront, event, or person within a kilometre of her flat. She read them every day. Read them. Read them again.

At some unidentifiable point she drifted off to Chatswood — perhaps a news item mentioned something, perhaps the planning system picked a point that looked "like something to do." In any case she ended up at Silkari, on the 12th floor of that block. The number of people who passed her — roughly the same as the no-push version, 90. But **the number of times she actually looked up came to 8. Lower than the no-push version.** Across 14 days she drifted furthest — and saw the least.

The 8 times she did look up, she did not see Lane Cove faces — she saw a 57-year-old manager who lived in the building, an 18-year-old student she occasionally shared a lift with. Two strangers, in a building she did not belong to, glanced at — sometimes, bewilderedly — by her. She did not know their names. She had no intention of getting to know them.

She also wrote slightly fewer reflections in this universe — the other three of her wrote 36 each; this one wrote 33. The three missing reflections are probably the moments in that 12th-floor flat, 4.5 kilometres from anywhere she knew, where there was simply nothing to reflect on. The people in front of her she did not know; the streets under her feet she had not walked; the news on her phone had nothing to do with the breakfast she had that morning.

"Nearby blindness" is not only about looking down at your phone and missing the person next to you. It can take another form: **attention pulled away by a news item that has nothing to do with what is under your feet, and the person drifts with it** — drifts to a strange 12th-floor flat, eyes fixed permanently on the screen, the body merely a container parked somewhere geographically.

Phone friction · she looked up 21 times, and saw a person at restaurant 1021

In this universe, her phone is almost silent. 6 pushes across 14 days — the fewest of any of the four versions of her. None tells her "go here." Each tells her to **look up**:
"Next time you're in the lift — don't look down. You might know that face."
"Five hours of screen is no match for five minutes on the Plaza. The neighbours at the corner will notice you."
"There is no real conversation on the screen. There is one on the Plaza bench."

None of them tell her where to go, what to do, or when to meet. Each is just a sentence, about where her eyes ought to rest. She reads all six.

In the small hours of May 5 she is not at home. She is not at the Plaza either. She is in a small shop on the middle stretch of Burns Bay Road — 1021 Mediterranean. A not-large Mediterranean restaurant in town: wooden tables, oil-painting-style lamps, not many people at dinner. Once she got there she hardly moved. At the snapshot moment she is still sitting in that shop.

107 people pass her — slightly more than the no-push version's 90. But the times she actually looked up come to **21** — nearly double the no-push version's eleven.
Looking up does not need a specific destination — only a single line to pull her out of the phone. Six look-up reminders translate into 21 actual lifts of the head over 14 days.

What matters more is that across those 21 a face starts to recur — a 40-year-old unemployed young man, in the corner of 1021, "*far more than anyone else*," she writes in her reflection. The same corner, the same table, the same glass of water. She remembers where he sits. She remembers the glass in front of him.
She did not speak to him — she still only sat down to a conversation with 4 people, the same as the other three universes — **but she saw him**. In a place where someone shows up repeatedly, she also shows up repeatedly; in the corner of each other's vision the two of them gradually became each other's "that face."

Reverse push did not "make her use the phone less." It walked her out of the house to a place where she would **look up**. Six reminders, 21 lifts of the head — a slightly higher rate than the "go to the Soka Centre" universe (30 pushes, 45 lifts).
The most effective kind of push, perhaps, was never "tell you where to go." It was "remind you to look up."

Not a single line of code told her to go to 1021. The reverse push only did one very small thing: it nudged her `screen_time_weight` down, so that the next time the planning system calculated the pull of her surroundings, her `sight_radius` automatically opened up — and the small shop on the middle of Burns Bay Road with the wooden tables and oil-painting-style lamps happened to fall inside her line of sight. She left the house, walked over, sat down. **One weight was changed, and the system grew the next step on its own.**

The same 75-year-old retired volunteer. The same 20-event life history. The same daughter in the eastern suburbs. The same evening cup of barley tea. The same Lane Cove.
The same 14 days. Four different phones.

Under those four phones, she looked up **11**, **45**, **8**, and **21** times respectively.
Each time she looked up, an unfamiliar face briefly entered her life.
Each time she looked down, a face walked past her — and did not, quite, happen.

> Inside this thousand-person algorithmic wind tunnel, Old He's 14 days offer a possibility the real world has perhaps not yet noticed:
> **Technology does not only have to be a machine that atomises people and strips their attention. Change a single line of distribution-weight logic, and an algorithm can equally well become a binder of "nearby" — pulling people out of the screen, and placing them back on the street under their feet.**

9 · The change across 14 days

At the end of each day the system has the LLM look over Old He's full behavioural log and generate a `reflection` event — a meta-awareness of her own behavioural patterns. These reflections are not written by Old He herself, they are generated by the system looking at the log. But they track the daily change in her behaviour.

```
> reflection · day 0 · 2026-04-22

Agent 405 repeatedly completed wait actions at the destination, interspersed with
encountering the same four agents at building_2022, indicating a cyclical process of
waiting and then encountering those agents。
```

```
> reflection · day 5 · 2026-04-27

Agent_405 has repeatedly encountered the same set of 73 unique entities at
shinnyo_australia, with some entities appearing twice (e.g., the 1-year-old student-
neighbour in statements 0 and 74).
```

```
> reflection · day 9 · 2026-05-01

All 100 MoveIntent statements returned the same exact result: already_at_location。
```

```
> reflection · day 12 · 2026-05-04

The only non-repetitive event in the neighbour's log is the encounter with the 77-year-
old retired neighbour, suggesting it was stuck or stationary and that entity was
repeatedly crossing its path.
```

At the moment of the May 5 snapshot, her `plan` field reads:

```
13:30 move → Shinnyo Australia · reason: drawn in by the hyperlocal
push · social intent: open_to_chat
```

"drawn in by the hyperlocal push" is the decision reason the system gave. "open_to_chat" is her disposition to conversation at the time. Her replan count for the day = 1.

Interlude · the daughter who does not exist

Before we go on, one thing has to be said out loud.

Across her four 14-day stretches, on almost every evening Old He video-calls the "daughter in Sydney's eastern suburbs." It is written in her plan; it is in the conversation with the 88-year-old retired neighbour — *"8:30 video call to the eastern suburbs, written on the fridge sticky-notes so I don't forget."* Her life_history holds concrete detail: in 2023 the daughter drove over from the eastern suburbs on Mother's Day, and they had a late lunch at Garfish in Crows Nest; on a stormy night in 2022 the daughter called to ask "*will it flood where you are?*" and she replied "*even the floods of the seventies didn't reach me*"; on the night the Queen died in 2022 she sent the daughter a text and the daughter replied with a single crown emoji.

> But in the database of the thousand synthetic residents of the Synthetic Socio Wind Tunnel, **no agent is linked as Old He's daughter**.
>
> In Old He's profile, `family_members = {}` — an empty dictionary. `household_role = "parent"` records that she is a parent, but no `a_43_XXXX` in the simulation points to "her child." Sydney's eastern suburbs are not even inside the geographical range of this simulation — Lane Cove, the thousand-person town, is the totality of this universe.
>
> So the phone she lifts every evening at 8:30, **there is no API on the other side**. Her LLM writes "video call," but no line of code connects to any other agent's input. The crown emoji, the line "Dad, you've lost weight" (drifted in by the LLM itself), the call asking "will it flood" — all of them are strings inside Old He's own memory_store, with no real response ever coming back.

> *The system gave her a person to worry about.*
> *The system did not assign that worry a recipient.*

This cuts a little sharper than "she only sat down to a conversation with 4 people across 14 days" — those 4 conversations, at least the other side is a real agent_id, with their own plan, their own memory, alive in some corner of the simulation in their own right.
But every evening at 8:30, in the moment she lifts the phone and says "hello, sweetheart," the socket on the other end has been empty all along.

This is, perhaps, the final mirror the simulation holds up to reality. In our own thousand-person town — in Lane Cove, in Melbourne's western suburbs, in the Huilongguan in Beijing — there are also many Old Hes, picking up the phone at 8:30 sharp each evening, speaking a paragraph into the screen. Whether someone is really listening on the other end — whether someone is typing, frowning, sending back an emoji — is not always something we can verify.
For some evenings of worry, we cannot be sure whether, on the other end, there is an API.

10 · One of a thousand stories

Old He is not a special case. Across the thousand synthetic residents, 227 went through a similar change across the 14 days — pulled out of their daily radius by a push, repeatedly running into a set of neighbours they had never seen before, and forming a new fixed routine.

But each person has their own version. The same hyperlocal_push: Mike, a 26-year-old engineer, went to 1021 Mediterranean; Frank, a 64-year-old construction worker, was hooked by a book club for *A Short History of Lane Cove* and turned up at the Soka Centre; Lucy, a 29-year-old unemployed young woman, walked 3.1 km to PLC Sydney Preschool.

This is the story of a virtual city — but the question it discusses is real: can a single push change the radius of one specific person's world? The simulation says it can. Old He's 14 days of real data confirms it.

→ Back to the thousand-resident statistical report

Appendix · Data spec

How much data sits behind this ten-chapter longform about a single 75-year-old? Laid out, all of it — an honest "data ledger," and also a not particularly modest "synthetic-demographic scale statement."

⊙ OLD HE ALONE, ACROSS 4 PARALLEL UNIVERSES, ACROSS 14 DAYS, PRODUCED —

3,432
system-recorded events
(on average 61 per simulation day)

2,260
action records
every walk / pause / return home

841
"in-frame" co-presence events

141
LLM-generated reflections

same building / street segment + same 5-minute window. Of these, only a small fraction are actually "glimpsed" (passing the attention gate).

36 per universe; GD has 3 fewer

62

push deliveries

0 + 30 + 30 + 6; she opened 62 of them

80

life-history memories

20 × 4 universes (the same past)

48

shared-memory events

city knowledge shared with neighbours

16

full conversations

4 × 4 universes, ~11,148 words of raw LLM text

956

location visits

383 + 191 + 185 + 197 (repeats counted)

1,166

GPS position samples

the real trajectory points after downsampling

⊙ THE INFORMATION-DIFFUSION NETWORK AROUND HER (SINGLE-UNIVERSE AVERAGE) —

~758

pieces of gossip her ears have heard

746–777 per universe, from ~750 neighbours in the thousand-person town of Lane Cove

~991

neighbours have heard each of her stories

the retold reach of each of her 4 conversations, single-universe / single-info average

4 / 4

conversations she actually sat down to

4 in each of the 4 parallel universes — the push changes nothing about this number

0 → 17

hops: the deepest piece of gossip her ears have heard

the same info travelled 17 times around the thousand-person town before it reached her ears — most of the way around Lane Cove

⊙ THE VIRTUAL LANE COVE THAT CARRIES HER —

5,722

real Lane Cove buildings

each with real latitude/longitude / use / polygon

4,257

real outdoor areas

streets / parks / plazas / coastlines

14,903

atlas topology connections

door-to-door / intersection-to-intersection

1,000

synthetic neighbours

each with a complete past / personality / family / occupation

⊙ ZOOM OUT TO THE FULL SIMULATION SCALE —

16,128,000

agent-ticks

1,000 neighbours × 4 universes × 14 days × 288 ticks = **16.1 M**

56,000

simulated person-days

1,000 × 4 × 14, equivalent to a town living for 56,000 days

~1.0 M

LLM calls (rough estimate)

each agent runs plan/replan/reflect/dialogue ~18 times per day on average

2.05 GB

snapshot files

4 .json files, each 460–525 MB

The above is the data from one run of ***seed 43****. The closed-loop dataset requires* ***three seeds (43 / 44 / 45)*** *×* ***4 variants*** *=* ***12 independent 14-day Lane Coves****. All of the statistics are written up in the main report ↗.*

> The ten-chapter story you have just finished about Old He is, inside that pile of data, **one thread** about **one 75-year-old retired volunteer**.
> Stories of this kind, in this simulation, exist 999 more times — each with their own four universes, their own 14 days, their own "that person" they keep running into.